

Parent Guide — senior / module-02- panchabhuta

IKS Curriculum

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Parent Guide — Module 2: Pañcabhūta (Senior)

Your student's age: Senior (Grades 9–12) · **Module length:** 10 sessions × 45 min

What your student is learning

This is a comparative-philosophy module at undergraduate-introductory level: - **The full 25-tattva enumeration** of Sāṅkhya philosophy (not just 5 elements). - **Primary-source reading** — at least one Sanskrit verse (SB 3.26.36) in IAST with word-by-word gloss. - **Cross-cultural comparison** — Sāṅkhya vs. Empedocles vs. Aristotle vs. modern science. - **A 5-page argumentative paper** with cited primary, secondary, and comparative sources.

What's at stake

Your student will engage these honest questions: - Is the Sāṅkhya framework “outdated” by modern science, or addressing different questions? - Does Sāṅkhya's inclusion of consciousness (puruṣa, the 25th tattva) anticipate the “hard problem” of modern philosophy of mind? - Should classical Indian intellectual frameworks be integrated into mainstream science class? (The Day 7 structured debate.)

Paper expectations

5–6 pages, double-spaced. Required: - Clear thesis in opening paragraph. - At least one verse from primary scripture (IAST + translation). - At least one secondary scholarly source (Larson, Plofker, Bryant). - At least one comparative or modern source (Empedocles, Aristotle, NCERT chemistry). - One steel-manned counter-argument with reasoned response. - Works-cited in MLA or Chicago format.

Plagiarism is taken seriously — invented citations score 0 on multiple criteria.

How to help

Helpful: - Be a thinking partner. Listen to their thesis. Push back gently. “*What's the strongest counter-argument someone could make?*” - Read their draft and circle the parts that aren't clear. Don't rewrite. - For the Day 7 debate: ask them to defend a position they DON'T hold. (This is the hardest form of argument.)

Not helpful: - Writing portions of the paper for them. - Insisting on a “correct” position on the Day 7 debate. The discipline is in articulating any position fairly, not in reaching the right answer. - Avoiding the historical / cultural sensitivities. Talk about them honestly.

On the politics

This module touches on contested terrain. Some families have strong views on whether IKS belongs in science class. The classroom frame: - Both positions (“yes” and “no”) can be defended. - The skill is articulating each position on its best terms. - Your student will form their own view through engagement, not by being told.

You may disagree with their conclusions. That’s healthy. Disagree by *defending your view*, not by dismissing theirs.

Assessment

- Summative quiz: 35 marks.
- Paper: 65 marks (heavy weight on counter-argument quality and source diversity).
- Total: 100 marks.

Grading bands: Distinction (85+), Merit (70+), Pass (55+), Resit (<55).

What success looks like

By end of module, your student can: - Read a Sanskrit verse with translation and discuss it. - Compare Sāṅkhya and Aristotle’s element schemes structurally, with one specific point each captures that the other doesn’t. - Write a research paper that holds multiple frameworks simultaneously without collapsing them. - Disagree with a peer’s position without strawmanning it.

Want to go further?

After this module, suggested reading: - Larson, G. J. (1979). *Classical Sāṅkhya: An Interpretation of its History and Meaning*. - Plofker, K. (2009). *Mathematics in India*. - Bryant, E. F. (2009). *The Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali*.

All available in major academic libraries.

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 2 (Senior) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance

Day	Session	File	Output
1	Hook: A Persistent Question	days/day-01-hook.md	Opening discussion

Day	Session	File	Output
2	The Sāṅkhya Tattva Ladder	days/day-02-tattvas.md	Diagram of 25 tattvas
3	Quality-Count + Tanmātras	days/day-03-tanmatras.md	Concept check
4	Empedocles, Aristotle, and the Greek Four	days/day-04-greek-comparison.md	Comparison essay draft
5	Primary Source Reading	days/day-05-primary-source.md	Formative quiz
6	The Modern Lens	days/day-06-modern.md	Reflection
7	Discussion: IKS in Science Class	days/day-07-discussion.md	Oral assessment
8	Project Session 1	days/day-08-project-session-1.md	Paper outline
9	Project Session 2	days/day-09-project-session-2.md	Paper draft
10	Final Assessment	days/day-10-final-assessment.md	Summative + paper

Pacing notes

- This is a reading-and-writing heavy module. Build in time for *quiet reading* and *quiet drafting*.
- The Day 5 primary-source reading is the most demanding session — students read a Sanskrit verse with transliteration and grapple with the meaning. Schedule it when energy is highest.
- Day 7 debate can run long. Cap at 35 min.
- Paper drafts (Day 9): students should leave class with at least 2 pages drafted.

What students leave with

- Working vocabulary for Sāṅkhya philosophy (tattva, prakṛti, puruṣa, guṇa).
- Ability to read a short Sanskrit verse with translation and discuss it.
- Comparative analytical writing.
- One original argumentative paper.
- The habit of holding multiple frameworks simultaneously without collapsing them into one another.

Homework

Homework — Module 2 Pañcabhūta (Senior)

Day 1 → Day 2

Reading: SB 2.10.3 from the cache (IAST + translation). Write 1 question you have about the verse.

Time: 20 min.

Day 2 → Day 3

Reading: Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya*, opening chapter on tattva enumeration (teacher's 1-page summary).

Time: 25 min.

Day 3 → Day 4

Reading: Empedocles fragment B17 (translation in handout). Note: how does Love-and-Strife differ from the Sāṃkhya guṇa doctrine?

Time: 25 min.

Day 4 → Day 5

Practise: Try reading SB 3.26.36 in IAST aloud (in handout). Don't worry about perfect pronunciation.

Time: 15 min.

Day 5 → Day 6

Writing: Submit the in-class quiz follow-up — 1 paragraph reflection on what reading a Sanskrit verse felt like.

Time: 20 min.

Day 6 → Day 7

Preparation for debate: Choose your position (Integration / Separation / Hybrid). Prepare your 2-minute opening argument + 1 steel-manned response.

Time: 30 min.

Day 7 → Day 8

Submit project plan: working title, thesis paragraph, 3 source citations.

Time: 30 min.

Day 8 → Day 9

Draft: Aim for 1.5–2 pages drafted at home.

Time: 60–90 min.

Day 9 → Day 10

Finalise: Complete draft, proofread, format. Submit tomorrow.

Time: 60–90 min.